

Zusammenfassung: Bernadotte E. Schmitt – „Triple Alliance and Triple Entente, 1902–1914“

Der Historiker Bernadotte E. Schmitt untersucht in seinem Aufsatz die Entwicklung der europäischen Bündnissysteme in den Jahren vor dem Ersten Weltkrieg. Im Mittelpunkt steht die Frage, wie sich die beiden großen Machtblöcke – die Triple Alliance aus Deutschland, Österreich-Ungarn und Italien sowie die Triple Entente aus Großbritannien, Frankreich und Russland – herausbildeten und welche Rolle sie für die politische Spannung in Europa spielten. Schmitt zeigt, dass diese Bündnisse ursprünglich überwiegend defensiven Charakter hatten und zunächst nicht als unmittelbare Vorbereitung eines großen Krieges gedacht waren.

Verträge zwischen den Staaten verpflichteten die Bündnispartner vor allem dazu, einander im Falle eines Angriffs zu unterstützen. In dieser frühen Phase stabilisierte das Bündnissystem teilweise sogar das europäische Gleichgewicht der Mächte. Zu Beginn des 20. Jahrhunderts standen sich die Bündnisse daher eher nebeneinander als direkt feindlich gegenüber.

Im Laufe der Jahre veränderte sich jedoch die politische Lage. Besonders nach 1902 kam es zu diplomatischen Entwicklungen, die das Machtgefüge Europas nachhaltig beeinflussten. Großbritannien näherte sich Frankreich an, was schließlich zur Entente Cordiale führte. Später folgte eine Verständigung zwischen Großbritannien und Russland. Dadurch entstand allmählich ein zweiter politischer Block, der der bestehenden Allianz der Mittelmächte gegenüberstand.

Schmitt zeigt außerdem, dass internationale Krisen – etwa die Marokkokrisen oder Konflikte auf dem Balkan – das Misstrauen zwischen den Großmächten verstärkten. Diese Krisen führten dazu, dass sich die Bündnisse enger zusammenschlossen und militärische Kooperationen ausgebaut wurden. Gleichzeitig entwickelte sich ein intensiver Rüstungswettlauf, da jede Großmacht versuchte, ihre Sicherheit durch stärkere Armeen und Flotten zu garantieren.

Paradoxerweise führte dieser Versuch der Selbstabsicherung zu wachsender Unsicherheit. Militärische Planungen, Bündnisverpflichtungen und diplomatische Spannungen griffen zunehmend ineinander. Die politischen Entscheidungsträger gerieten dadurch unter Zeitdruck, weil Mobilisierungspläne und militärische Strategien schnelle Entscheidungen verlangten.

Schmitt kommt zu dem Ergebnis, dass der Erste Weltkrieg nicht allein durch ein aggressives Bündnis ausgelöst wurde. Vielmehr standen sich zwei Machtblöcke gegenüber, deren Interessen, Bündnisse und militärische Planungen immer stärker miteinander kollidierten. In dieser angespannten Situation konnte ein regionaler Konflikt schnell zu einer internationalen Krise eskalieren. Der Krieg war somit weniger das Ergebnis eines einzelnen Plans als vielmehr die Folge eines komplexen europäischen Bündnis- und Machtsystems.



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TRIPLE ALLIANCE AND TRIPLE ENTENTE, 1902-1914¹

THE causes of the Great War have been analyzed from many points of view. The explanation usually offered is the vaulting ambition of this or that great power, Germany being most often selected as the offender. Persons internationally minded insist that rabid nationalism was a universal disease and draw vivid pictures of the European anarchy. The pacifist points to the bloated armaments, and the socialist can see only the conflict of rival imperialisms. Facts galore can be cited in support of each thesis. Yet no one of these explanations is entirely satisfactory, or the lot of them taken together. Why should the different kinds of dynamite explode simultaneously in August, 1914? Why, for instance, should a war break out between Great Britain and Germany at a moment when their disputes were seemingly on the verge of adjustment?² There must have been some connecting link which acted as a chain of powder between the various accumulations of explosive material. And so there was. As one peruses the innumerable memoirs by politicians,³ soldiers,⁴ and sailors,⁵ from the German emperor⁶ to obscure diplomatists,⁷ or tries

¹ A paper read at the meeting of the American Historical Association at Columbus, Dec. 28, 1923.

² B. E. Schmitt, *England and Germany, 1740-1914* (1916), pp. 191-195, 368-374; Sir A. W. Ward and G. P. Gooch, *Cambridge History of British Foreign Policy*, III. 476-481 (1923).

³ H. H. Asquith, *Genesis of the War* (London, 1923); W. S. Churchill, *World Crisis*, I. (1923); Viscount Haldane, *Before the War* (1920). R. Poincaré, *Les Origines de la Guerre* (1921); R. Viviani, *Réponse au Kaiser* (1923), English translation, *As We See It* (1923). T. von Bethmann-Hollweg, *Betrachtungen zum Weltkrieg*, I. (1919); Karl Helfferich, *Der Weltkrieg*, I. (1919); G. von Jagow, *Ursachen und Ausbruch des Weltkrieges* (1919). Graf O. Czernin, *Im Weltkrieg* (1919); B. Molden, *Alois Graf Aehrenthal* (1916). G. Giolitti, *Memorie della Mia Vita* (1922). A. P. Izvolski, *Recollections of a Foreign Minister* (1921). Take Jonescu, *Some Personal Impressions* (1920). Djemal Pasha, *Memoirs of a Turkish Statesman* (1922).

⁴ Conrad von Hötzendorf, *Aus Meiner Dienstzeit* (1921-1923); A. von Margutti, *Vom Alten Kaiser* (1921), English translation, *The Emperor Francis Joseph and his Times* (1922); H. von Moltke, *Erinnerungen, Briefe, Dokumente* (1922).

⁵ Lord Fisher, *Memories* (London, 1919) and *Records* (*ibid.*, 1919); A. von Tirpitz, *Erinnerungen* (1919).

⁶ Wilhelm II., *Erinnerungen* (1922).

⁷ Sir G. W. Buchanan, *My Mission to Russia* (1923). G. P. Deville, *L'Entente, la Grèce, et la Bulgarie* (1919); A. Dumaine, *La Dernière Ambassade de France en Autriche* (1921); M. Paléologue, *La Russie des Tsars pendant la Grande Guerre* (1922). H. Freiherr von Eckardstein, *Lebenserinnerungen und Politische Denk-*

to digest the thousands of documents published since 1918 from the German,⁸ Austrian,⁹ Serbian,¹⁰ Russian,¹¹ French,¹² Belgian,¹³ and British¹⁴ archives, the conviction grows that it was the schism of Europe in Triple Alliance and Triple Entente which fused the various quarrels and forces into one gigantic struggle for the balance of power; and the war came in 1914 because then, for the first time, the lines were sharply drawn between the two rival groups, and neither could yield on the Serbian issue without seeing the balance pass definitely to the other side.

This disastrous result was the more tragic because both groups were formed in the interests of peace, and were, originally at least, defensive in character. Article I. of the Austro-German treaty of

würdigkeiten (1919-1921), English translation, *Ten Years at the Court of St. James'* (1922), *Die Isolierung Deutschlands* (1921); Otto Hammann, *Der Neue Kurs* (1918), *Zur Vorgeschichte des Weltkrieges* (1919), *Um den Kaiser* (1919), *Der Missverständne Bismarck* (1921), *Bilder aus der Letzten Kaiserzeit* (1922); Freiherr von Schoen, *Erlebtes* (1921), English translation, *Memoirs of an Ambassador* (1922). J. von Szilassy, *Der Untergang der Donau-Monarchie* (1921); Prince L. Windischgraetz, *My Memoirs* (1921). A. Nekludoff, *Diplomatic Reminiscences* (1920); Baron Rosen, *Forty Years of Diplomacy* (1922); E. de Schelling, *Recollections of a Russian Diplomat* (1918). M. Bogitshevitch, *Causes of the War* (1920).

⁸ *Deutschland Schuldig?* (German *Weissbuch* for the Paris Peace Conference, Berlin, 1919); Graf M. Montgelas and W. Schücking, *Die Deutschen Dokumente zum Kriegausbruch* (1919); P. Dirr, *Bayerische Dokumente zum Kriegausbruch* (1922); *Stenographische Berichte und Weissbücher des Parlamentarischen Untersuchungsausschusses zur Vorgeschichte des Weltkrieges* (1920-1921), English translation, *Official German Documents relating to the World War* (1923). The great collection of Foreign Office papers, *Die Grosse Politik der Europäischen Kabinette, 1871-1914*, is not yet available for the period covered by this paper.

⁹ A. F. Pribram, *The Secret Treaties of Austria-Hungary, 1879-1914* (1920-1921); *Diplomatische Aktenstücke zur Vorgeschichte des Krieges 1914* (Vienna, 1919, 3 vols.), English translation, *Official Files pertaining to Pre-War History* (1919-1920). H. Friedjung, *Das Zeitalter des Imperialismus* (1920-1922), often quotes from unpublished documents.

¹⁰ *Deutschland Schuldig?* annex VI.; also in Bogitshevitch.

¹¹ E. Laloy, *Les Documents Secrets . . . publiés par les Bolchéviks* (1920); B. von Siebert, *Diplomatische Aktenstücke zur Geschichte der Entente-politik der Vorkriegsjahre* (1921), English edition, *Entente Diplomacy and the World*, by G. A. Schreiner (1921); *Un Livre Noir: Diplomatie d'Avant-Guerre d'après les Documents des Archives Russes, 1910-1914* (1922-1923); G. von Romberg, *Die Fälschungen des Russischen Orangebuches* (1922).

¹² *Documents Diplomatiques: L'Alliance Franco-Russe* (1918); *Les Accords Franco-Italiens de 1900-1902* (1919); *Affaires Balkaniques, 1912-1914* (1922). Bourgeois and Pagès, *Les Origines et les Responsabilités de la Grande Guerre* (1921), quote frequently from unpublished documents.

¹³ B. Schwertfeger, *Zur Europäischen Politik, 1897-1914* (1919), documents captured by the Germans.

¹⁴ Some documents are printed or quoted from by Mr. Asquith and Mr. Churchill.

1879 read: "Should, contrary to their hope and against the loyal desire of the two High Contracting Parties, one of the two Empires be attacked by Russia, the High Contracting Parties are bound to come to the assistance one of the other."¹⁵ And according to Article II. of the Triple Alliance of 1882: "In case Italy, without direct provocation on her part, should be attacked by France for any reason whatsoever, the two other Contracting Parties shall be bound to lend help and assistance with all their forces to the Party attacked. This same obligation shall devolve upon Italy in case of any aggression without direct provocation by France against Germany."¹⁶ The Franco-Russian alliance of 1893 was equally explicit: "If France is attacked by Germany, or by Italy supported by Germany, Russia shall employ all her available forces to attack Germany. If Russia is attacked by Germany, or by Austria supported by Germany, France shall employ all her available forces to fight Germany."¹⁷

No semblance of aggressive intent is to be found in such language, and at the opening of our unhappy century, the alliance system seemed to have justified itself. There was little talk of a European conflagration. Triple and Dual Alliances stood—to modify an apt phrase of Mr. Winston Churchill—side by side, not face to face. Even had they been inclined to try conclusions with each other, the balance of military power was sufficiently even to make the result doubtful. So long as Great Britain, who had her quarrels with both groups, stood aside, fear of her intervention, if no other reason, assured the continuance of peace. Moreover, the two danger-zones of Europe, Alsace-Lorraine and the Near East, were relatively quiet.

In the year 1902, however, two diplomatic manoeuvres were executed which profoundly altered the situation. In April a German diplomatist overheard Joseph Chamberlain and the French ambassador in London using the words "Morocco" and "Egypt" so frequently that he divined the coming change in British policy;¹⁸ the first steps towards the Entente Cordiale were indeed being taken. And a little later Italy gave to France the secret promise of "a strict neutrality . . . in case France, as the result of a direct provocation, should find herself compelled, in defence of her honor or of her security, to take the initiative of a declaration of war";¹⁹ a promise which a semi-official French writer admits²⁰ to have been "difficilement conciliable" with the Triple Alliance. Since in 1914 Great

¹⁵ Pribram, I. 27.

¹⁶ *Ibid.*, I. 67.

¹⁷ *Ibid.*, II. 215.

¹⁸ Eckardstein, *Lebenserinnerungen*, II. 376–377 (*Ten Years*, p. 228).

¹⁹ Pribram, II. 251.

²⁰ Bourgeois and Pagès, p. 301, note 1.

Britain stood by France and Italy refused to follow her allies, there seems to be something in the German contention that the war was the consequence of a plan long meditated and carefully matured.

The Triple Alliance undoubtedly passed through a period of ineffectiveness. In the Moroccan controversy Italy supported France against Germany; in the Bosnian crisis she disapproved of the Austrian procedure, and perhaps dallied with the idea of mobilization against her ally.²¹ This was followed by a secret agreement with Russia in October, 1909,²² which was meant to signalize "the complete unity of the views and interests of the two governments".²³ No wonder that it put the Austrians "in an extraordinarily bad humor"²⁴ or that the French and the Russians came to look upon Italy as "a restraining influence" in the alliance!²⁵ But the Marquis of San Giuliano, who was foreign minister from 1910 to 1914, was a firm believer in the Triple Alliance and restored its vitality. Not only was it renewed at the time of the Balkan wars,²⁶ during which Italy and Austria pursued a common policy, but it was supplemented by an elaborate naval convention for operations in the Mediterranean against the fleets of the Triple Entente.²⁷ More than that: in the spring of 1914 the German general staff secured the written promise of three Italian army corps and two cavalry divisions for use against France.²⁸ "The fidelity of Italy to the alliance", wrote Count von Moltke, the chief of the German staff, after the outbreak of the war, "was hardly open to doubt."²⁹ Thus so far was Germany from being isolated that in 1914 her political, military, and naval arrangements were more complete than at any time since the formation of the Alliance thirty-two years before.³⁰

The Triple Entente was originally a loose diplomatic arrangement represented by the Anglo-French convention of 1904 and the Anglo-

²¹ T. von Sosnosky, in *Contemporary Review*, July, 1923, p. 64.

²² Text in *Livre Noir*, I. 357-358.

²³ Izvolski to Russian ambassador in Berlin, Nov. 4, 1909, Siebert, p. 454.

²⁴ Russian ambassador in Vienna to Izvolski, Oct. 27, 1909, *ibid.*, p. 451.

²⁵ Izvolski to Sazonov, June 6, 1912, *ibid.*, p. 469.

²⁶ Pribram, I. 245.

²⁷ *Ibid.*, I. 283-305.

²⁸ Moltke, p. 8; H. F. Helmolt, *Die Geheime Vorgeschichte des Weltkrieges* (1915), p. 85.

²⁹ Moltke, p. 9.

³⁰ Cf. Col. Hugo Schäfer, "Die Militärischen Abmachungen des Dreibundes vor dem Weltkriege", in *Preussische Jahrbücher*, May, 1922, pp. 203-214. Complaints about isolation come with very bad grace from Germany, for Bismarck's favorite policy for twenty years was to keep France isolated. Also William II. seems to have tried several times to isolate Great Britain (see note 46). Germany always had Austria as an ally.

Russian convention of 1907. In so far as the purpose of the former was to exclude the Germans from Morocco and of the latter to keep them out of Persia,³¹ the two agreements were directed against Germany, whose policies and ambitions were causing grave anxiety in many quarters; but, unlike both Triple and Dual Alliances, they did not refer specifically to European politics and contained no provisions for action in the event of European complications. Yet in 1906 military conversations were opened between the French and British general staffs, "a step", says Mr. Churchill, "of profound significance and of far-reaching reactions", for the discussions "constituted an exceedingly potent tie".³² Two years later, at the meeting of King Edward VII. and Tsar Nicholas II. at Reval, Sir Charles Hardinge, who accompanied the king as representative of the Foreign Office, expressed the opinion that "Russia should be as strong as possible on land and at sea";³³ while Stolypin, the Russian premier, told Sir John Fisher that "he was devoting all his life to make [the western] frontier impregnable against Germany, both in men and munitions, and strategic arrangements".³⁴ And on the morrow of the Bosnian crisis, the conclusion was drawn in Paris, so the Russian ambassador reported, that "the Western Powers, together with Russia, must now pay attention to the systematic development of their armed forces in order to be able . . . to set up on their part demands which would restore the political balance which has now been displaced in favor of Germany and Austria".³⁵ Thus the idea of common action against the Central Powers had begun to take root.

This development was due, as the German historian Johannes Haller admirably explains,³⁶ to the folly of Prince Bülow, chancellor from 1900 to 1909, and his *adlatus* Fritz von Holstein, who after the retirement of Bismarck pulled the strings in the German Foreign Office.³⁷ The British *rapprochement* with France was begun rather reluctantly, only after vain endeavors to come to terms with Germany.

³¹ By Article III. of the Secret Articles of the Anglo-French Convention of Apr. 8, 1904, Spain was to pledge herself not to alienate any territory in Morocco that might be placed under her authority or in her sphere of influence. The Persian situation is discussed in the lengthy correspondence between the British and Russian governments with reference to the Bagdad Railway. See, e.g., Izvolski to Benckendorff, Dec. 19, 1907, Siebert, p. 319, and Sazonov's report to the Tsar in 1912, *Livre Noir*, II. 351.

³² Churchill, I. 27.

³³ Izvolski to Benckendorff, June 19, 1908, Siebert, p. 778.

³⁴ Fisher, *Memories*, p. 237.

³⁵ Nelidov to Izvolski, Apr. 1, 1909, Siebert, p. 114.

³⁶ Johannes Haller, *Die Ära Bülow* (1922).

³⁷ The available information about Holstein is put together by G. P. Gooch in *Cambridge Historical Journal*, I. (1923).

From German sources³⁸ the story has been told how between 1895 and 1901 Great Britain proposed to Germany a partition of Turkey,³⁹ a partition of Morocco, and ultimately an out-and-out alliance. But William II. and Bülow, largely under the influence of Holstein, declined each and every overture.⁴⁰ Germany, they said, must keep her hands free; they hoped to continue Bismarck's policy of the *zwei Eisen*, that is, of playing off Russia against Great Britain,⁴¹ and, in any case, they were persuaded that Germany was strong enough to pursue an independent world policy in all directions. "There is no balance of power in Europe", confided the emperor to a British statesman, "except me—me and my twenty-five corps."⁴² The

³⁸ Eckardstein and Hammann tell practically all that is known, the latter's account being summarized in *Der Missverständne Bismarck*, pp. 63-94; see also Ward and Gooch, vol. III., ch. IV.

³⁹ Sir Valentine Chirol has challenged this (*Times*, Sept. 11 and 13, 1920), declaring that the proposal for partition came from the German emperor. But the documents published in *Die Grosse Politik der Europäischen Kabinette*, X. 3-36 (1923), show that the suggestion was Lord Salisbury's. Salisbury wished to maintain the Ottoman Empire as long as possible, but thought it well to be prepared for its collapse. The German emperor and his Foreign Office were very suspicious of this manoeuvre.

⁴⁰ Holstein insisted that Great Britain should join the Triple Alliance, but both Salisbury and Lord Lansdowne were skeptical about the future of Austria-Hungary. The views of Eckardstein are sharply criticized and those of Holstein defended by Maximilian von Hagen, "Die Bündnispolitik des Deutschen Reiches", in *Preussische Jahrbücher*, November, 1921, pp. 145-171.

⁴¹ A bitter controversy rages in Germany over the real purposes of Bismarck's complicated manoeuvres. Tirpitz and Reventlow believe that the old chancellor's political testament was the admonition to keep the wire to St. Petersburg open; Hammann and Eckardstein insist that the ultimate aim of his policy was to draw Great Britain into the Triple Alliance. Bismarck's own utterances support each view! On the whole, Hammann and Eckardstein seem to have the better of the argument, for perhaps in 1875, probably in 1879, and certainly in 1876 and again in 1889, Bismarck made definite overtures to Great Britain for an alliance. The fullest discussion is in F. Rachfahl, *Deutschland und die Weltpolitik*, Band I., *Die Bismarck'sche Zeit* (1923), which is based on *Die Grosse Politik*. In any case it is a commentary on the political wisdom of the two nations that, at the time when Germany was confident that she could go it alone, Great Britain, with far greater resources, should have deemed it necessary to liquidate her difficulties and seek new friends. What the statesmen of the Guilelman era overlooked, or preferred to forget, was that when Bismarck opposed Great Britain in Africa—and their naval programme was a much greater challenge!—he had Jules Ferry in one pocket and the Three Emperors' League in the other; or that if he deemed it necessary to support Austria in the Balkans against Russia, he took care that Great Britain should line up behind Austria. Cf. J. V. Fuller, *Bismarck's Diplomacy at its Zenith* (1922).

⁴² Asquith, p. 20; cf. Eckardstein, *Lebenserinnerungen*, II. 265 (*Ten Years*, p. 192).

Triple Alliance, said Bülow in the Reichstag, is no longer "an absolute necessity".⁴³

It was with such convictions that the French pretensions in Morocco were challenged in the spring of 1905. There was no little justification for the German action; but when it was accompanied by threats of war,⁴⁴ when Bülow refused to consider proposals from Rouvier, the French premier, for a large economic collaboration and even a political reconciliation,⁴⁵ when King Edward learned of Emperor William's intrigues with the Tsar at Björkö,⁴⁶ the moral for France and Great Britain was obvious. So as regards Russia. Izvolski, the foreign minister who negotiated the understanding with Great Britain, was ready to make an agreement also with Germany.⁴⁷

⁴³ Speech in the Reichstag, Jan. 8, 1902. Bülow, *Reden*, II. 33.

⁴⁴ The outward sign was the brutal mission of Prince Henckel von Donnersmarck to Paris to demand the dismissal of Delcassé, under threat of war. Eckardstein records (*Die Isolierung Deutschlands*, pp. 111-112) that Bülow said to him at Karlsruhe, in May, 1905: "Wir sind in der Lage, es darauf ankommen zu lassen, ob Frankreich unsere Wünsche erfüllt oder nicht; sollte es sich nicht fügen, so würden wir natürlich die äussersten Konsequenzen daraus ziehen müssen"; and he expresses the conviction that Holstein was intriguing for war. William shortly afterwards said to Izvolski, then Russian minister in Copenhagen: "The question of Alsace-Lorraine is definitively solved, for France has refused to accept the duel which is offered her." Izvolski to Sazonov, Feb. 15, 1912, *Livre Noir*, II. 193-194; Izvolski, *Recollections*, pp. 67-68.

⁴⁵ Rouvier employed as his emissary Baron von Eckardstein, the German diplomatist, who, as councillor of the embassy in London, had conducted the negotiations for an Anglo-German alliance and after their failure had retired from the service. He was asked to come to Paris, where he was made acquainted with Rouvier's offers, which included a coaling-station for Germany on the Atlantic coast of Morocco. He proceeded to Karlsruhe, where William II. was at the moment, but was prevented by Bülow from seeing the emperor. Eckardstein, *Die Isolierung Deutschlands*, pp. 99 ff. Finally, he wrote a long and bitter letter to Holstein, protesting against the notion then prevalent in Germany that Great Britain would be indifferent to an attack on France, and throwing in the prophetic remark, "I have not the least doubt that ultimately America would also take side against us and bow (*hinauskomplimentieren*) us out of France". *Ibid.*, p. 160. Hammann (*Zur Vorgeschichte des Weltkrieges*, p. 141) notes that from this time even Jaurès ceased to preach against revenge, and that Romain Rolland came to believe in the danger of German imperialism.

⁴⁶ Eckardstein, *Lebenserinnerungen*, I. 218, *Isolierung Deutschlands*, p. 171. The Treaty of Björkö of July 24, 1905, between William II. and Nicholas II. is often represented as a personal move of the German emperor, and he certainly drew up the text which he persuaded the Tsar to sign in the absence of any ministers. But Bülow approved the idea of a Russo-German alliance (Hammann, *Zur Vorgeschichte des Weltkrieges*, pp. 142-143), and there is no little evidence to show that William II. was for years obsessed by the idea of organizing a Continental coalition against Great Britain. If Bülow had accepted Rouvier's proposals in May and June, 1905, it might not have been impossible to persuade France to adhere to the Treaty of Björkö.

⁴⁷ Schoen, p. 37.

But when during the Bosnian crisis the German government sent a note in support of Austria that could be and was interpreted as a threat,⁴⁸ the Russian government was bound to draw closer to its western associates.⁴⁹ Instead of smashing the Entente, as he boasted in 1913,⁵⁰ Bülow, more than any other individual, gave it life and being.

It was not yet, however, a closely-knit combination. France's interest in the Bosnian matter was decidedly reserved,⁵¹ and Russia took scant interest in Morocco. Indeed the retirement of Bülow so eased the tension that his successor, Bethmann-Hollweg, was able to approach each member of the Entente with suggestions for a deal. Long negotiations with France for a joint exploitation of Morocco;⁵² verbal assurances exchanged with the Russians at Potsdam in November, 1910, that "neither of the two governments would enter into an alliance which might be aimed against the other",⁵³ and a com-

⁴⁸ The Germans have always paraded the note as a piece of friendly advice which enabled Izvolski to get out of the diplomatic hole in which he found himself; Jagow, pp. 17-18. The crucial point was the statement that if Russia persisted in refusing to recognize the Austrian annexation, Germany would "let things take their course" (text in Hammann, *Bilder aus der Letzten Kaiserzeit*, pp. 155-156). As Austria had decided to declare war on Serbia, public opinion would have forced Russia to intervene, and Germany would then have gone to the rescue of her ally. The note was drafted by Kiderlen-Wächter, who was substituting for Schoen at the Foreign Office, and he boasted that "never would Schoen and Co. have ventured to do what I did on my own responsibility". Jonescu, p. 62. Schoen admits (p. 79) that the language was "very forcible".

⁴⁹ In 1911 Izvolski informed Schoen in Paris, where both were serving as ambassadors, that "Russia had so little got over her diplomatic defeat that she formed still closer relations with France and England". Schoen, pp. 80-81.

⁵⁰ Bülow, *Imperial Germany*, p. 65.

⁵¹ Franco-German relations were then tense because of the Casablanca incident. Clemenceau was more annoyed with Izvolski than with Aehrenthal; Molden, *Alois Graf Aehrenthal*, p. 82. Later France agreed to a German proposal for collective representations to Serbia in the interests of peace (Hammann, *Um den Kaiser*, p. 56), which made "a painful impression" in Russia (Izvolski to Nelidov, Feb. 27, 1909, Siebert, p. 76).

⁵² It was the failure of these negotiations which precipitated the Agadir crisis. In March, 1912, a final attempt to wean France from the "English alliance" was made by an informal suggestion of "a large measure of autonomy for Alsace-Lorraine", which, however, "was not listened to at Paris". Bourgeois and Pagès, p. 343.

⁵³ H. Oncken, in *Modern Germany in relation to the World War* (1915), p. 485. Bethmann, speaking in the Reichstag, said: "Neither Power commits itself to any combination which might have an aggressive point directed against the other." It is curious to observe that this is practically the same language which Sir Edward Grey proposed for an Anglo-German neutrality formula in 1912, which Bethmann then found insufficient. What interested the Russians most was Germany's promise to act once more as an "honest broker" between them and the Austrians. Sazonov's report to the Tsar, Nov. 17, 1910, *Livre Noir*, II. 331-334. Ac-

promise about the Bagdad Railway; efforts to arrive at an understanding with Great Britain about naval armaments: surely an accommodation could be reached in one direction. Unfortunately, Bethmann was never master of the political situation in Germany,⁵⁴ where there were two schools of expansionists. The militarists and the navy men saw in France and Great Britain, respectively, the rivals to be dealt with. Big business and high finance, on the other hand, dreamed of a German ascendancy in the Near East which must, sooner or later, arouse the opposition of Russia. The emperor, for his part, was equally anxious to be both Admiral of the Atlantic and King of Jerusalem. So the poor Chancellor, though keenly aware of Germany's dangerous position,⁵⁵ was pulled in opposite directions. He could never offer to any one Entente power an inducement sufficient to wean it away from the other two, and to some extent he was forced to carry on the very policies which had brought the Entente into existence. The *Panther's* "spring" at Agadir in 1911⁵⁶ was as legitimate, or the reverse, as the French occupation of Fez; the refusal to limit the navy so long as Great Britain clung to the Entente was intelligible; the Near Eastern policy, although it depended on the friendship of two ramshackle states, was less objectionable than some other forms of contemporary imperialism. But to pursue all three courses at once was politics of the worst sort, for it kept alive the distrust and suspicion of the Entente Powers, convinced them of the dangerous reality of German militarism, and made them more anxious than ever to act together.⁵⁷

Hence it was that the relations of France with Russia and of both with Great Britain began to grow steadily more intimate. The credit for this belongs in the first instance to M. Raymond Poincaré, who became premier of France in January, 1912. Under his masterly care, Franco-Russian relations, which had become somewhat tenuous while one ally was absorbed in Morocco and the other in Persia and the Far East,⁵⁸ were soon exhibiting the closest harmony. In the

cording to A. Hoyos, *Der Deutsch-Englische Gegensatz* (1922), p. 26, Russia received assurances that "the Eastern Question would not be precipitated by the Central Powers".

⁵⁴ Bethmann-Hollweg, I. 21-25, 99-104.

⁵⁵ *Ibid.*, pp. 1-20.

⁵⁶ Kiderlen-Wächter spent his Easter vacation drafting the note which was presented to the Powers on July 1, 1911, and in April informed a confidant of his intention of sending a war-ship to Agadir. C. von Weizsäcker, "Zum Marokkistreit", in *Deutsche Revue*, September, 1921, pp. 197-210.

⁵⁷ The Germans for their part were as fully convinced that they would be attacked by the Entente Powers.

⁵⁸ Izvolski frankly and brutally informed the French government that it ought to pay Germany's price for Morocco (J. Caillaux, *Agadir*, p. 147); in August

liquidation of the Tripolitan War and throughout the Balkan wars, Paris and St. Petersburg devised and applied a common policy, carrying London with them if possible. M. Poincaré repeatedly assured Izvolski, now ambassador to France, that the Republic would fulfill all the obligations of the alliance;⁵⁹ Izvolski took the Paris press into pay,⁶⁰ to create a sentiment for Russia and to strengthen the position of the premier whom he recognized as most useful to Russia. The French statesman urged the Tsar to proceed with the construction of strategic railways in Poland⁶¹ and sent Delcassé as his representative at the Russian court;⁶² the Russian ambassador, at least according to some persons, demanded that France revive the three years' military service.⁶³ The French and Russian general staffs, in annual conferences, perfected their plans for war, which were based on a joint offensive against Germany.⁶⁴ A naval convention was concluded.⁶⁵ Finally M. Poincaré went to Russia, and M. Sazonov, the foreign

Kiderlen was pleased to note "how correct the attitude of Russia has been in the Moroccan question" (Russian ambassador in Berlin to Neratov, Aug. 16, 1911, Siebert, p. 433). This attitude in no way deterred Russia from exerting constant pressure on France for support of its own policy at the Straits or of financial projects in China. Cf., e.g., Izvolski to de Selves, Nov. 4, 1911, *Livre Noir*, I. 157-159.

⁵⁹ According to Izvolski, M. Poincaré said to him on one occasion that "if Russia went to war, France would do likewise". Izvolski to Sazonov, Nov. 17, 1912, in *Livre Noir*, I. 346; Siebert, p. 586; *Deutschland Schuldig?* annex VIII., app. 5. M. Poincaré declares that in his conversations with the Russian statesmen, he always limited his promises to the obligations of the alliance, that is, that Russia must be attacked by Germany (*Origines de la Guerre*, p. 148), which is confirmed by Sazonov's report to the Tsar of his interview with Poincaré in August, 1912 (*Livre Noir*, II. 342). As regards the assurance of November, 1912, Izvolski, at Poincaré's request, sent a second telegram to make clear that the *casus foederis* must be involved (*ibid.*, I. 346-347; Siebert, pp. 586-587; *Deutschland Schuldig?* annex VIII., app. 6); and the French premier sent a telegram of his own to St. Petersburg (Poincaré to Louis, Nov. 19, 1912, no. 263, *Affaires Balkaniques*, I. 156). M. Poincaré kept reminding the Russian government that its policy in the Balkans must be communicated to and approved by France, and he several times prevented precipitate action.

⁶⁰ *Livre Noir*, I. 35-39, 128-129, 130, 148-149, 258-259.

⁶¹ Poincaré to the Tsar, Mar. 20, 1913, *Livre Noir*, II. 52.

⁶² F. Gouttenoire de Toury, *Poincaré a-t-il voulu la Guerre?* (1920) charged M. Poincaré with replacing Georges Louis by Delcassé because the former was too pacific, which M. Poincaré denied somewhat heatedly; *Le Matin*, Dec. 20, 1920. The Russian documents show that Sazonov and Izvolski complained of Louis's inaccurate reports and that Poincaré agreed to the appointment of another ambassador; this, however, was not done for nearly a year, until the premier had become president.

⁶³ Robert Dell, "A Great Criminal", in *Nation* (London), Aug. 23, 1919; E. D. Morel, *Truth and the War* (1916), pp. 152-153, quoting various French newspapers. The Russian documents are silent on the matter.

⁶⁴ The protocols for 1911-1913 are printed in *Livre Noir*, II. 419-437.

⁶⁵ Pribram, II. 223-225.

minister, expressed to the Tsar his hope that "in the event of a crisis in international relations" there would be at the helm in France, "if not M. Poincaré, at least a personality of the same power of decision and as free from the fear of taking responsibility".⁶⁶ The elevation of M. Poincaré to the presidency of the republic in no way interrupted the newly developed intimacy.⁶⁷ Indeed, from 1912 to the outbreak of the war, the Dual Alliance presented a solid front at every turn to the rival diplomatic group.

The commitments made by Great Britain to France in this same period are not easily defined. Mr. Asquith repeatedly assured Parliament that no engagements existed which would hamper its free decision, and in his recent book he insists that "the Entente . . . was never converted into an alliance".⁶⁸ This is true enough, technically, for in the well-known letters exchanged in November, 1912, between Sir Edward Grey and M. Paul Cambon,⁶⁹ the consultations of the military experts were affirmed not to be binding. But if we compare the last paragraph of each of these letters—

I agree that, if either Government had some grave reason to expect an unprovoked attack by a third Power, or something that threatened the general peace, it should immediately discuss with the other whether both Governments should act together to prevent aggression and to preserve peace, and, if so, what measures they would be prepared to take in common—

with the political clauses of the Franco-Russian alliance—

The two Governments declare that they will take counsel together upon every question of a nature to jeopardize the general peace; in case that peace should be actually in danger, and especially if one of the two parties should be threatened with an aggression, the two parties undertake to reach an understanding on the measures whose immediate and simultaneous adoption would be imposed upon the two Governments by the realization of this eventuality—⁷⁰

we can hardly make any distinction between the engagements contracted. The Anglo-French military and naval documents of 1910

⁶⁶ Sazonov to the Tsar, Aug. 17, 1912, *Livre Noir*, II. 345; Siebert, p. 796.

⁶⁷ "Tous les hommes d'état sont pénétrés de la conviction absolument générale et évidente que l'alliance de la Russie et de la France est l'unique facteur garantissant l'avenir de la France." Kokovtzev to the Tsar, Nov. 19, 1913, *Livre Noir*, II. 393. The Radical premier Doumergue declared to Izvolski in March, 1914: "L'alliance franco-russe donnait à la France une grande force pour assurer la défense de tous ses intérêts et apparaissait en même temps comme le gage le plus sûr de la conservation de la paix." Izvolski to Sazonov, *ibid.*, II. 255.

⁶⁸ Asquith, p. 57.

⁶⁹ British Diplomatic Correspondence, no. 105, enclosures 1 and 2, in *Collected Diplomatic Documents relating to the Outbreak of the European War*; Asquith, pp. 267–269.

⁷⁰ Pribram, II. 213.

and 1912 have not been published: probably they are labelled "conversations", like the Anglo-Belgian documents of 1906 and 1912⁷¹ discovered by the Germans, as opposed to the formal "conventions" of 1893 and 1912 between France and Russia.⁷² But Marshal Joffre has stated⁷³ that the French military plans were based on the assumption of British support, which had been worked out in every detail, and when the French concentrated their fleet in the Mediterranean, "the moral claims which France could make upon Great Britain if attacked by Germany . . . were enormously extended".⁷⁴ According to the Russian secret documents, both Sir Edward Grey and M. Poincaré informed M. Sazonov that there existed between the French and British governments "a verbal agreement, by virtue of which England had declared herself ready to come to the aid of France in the event of an attack by Germany".⁷⁵

If it is a problem in casuistry to reconcile such a statement with the language used by Mr. Asquith, the very great difficulty of the British government must in all fairness be recognized. The German navy was their constant preoccupation, since the Admiralty did not believe, for technical reasons,⁷⁶ that it was built for defense only; it was elementary prudence to perfect military and naval arrangements beforehand with the only possible ally. Ought then Great Britain to have contracted a formal and open alliance with France?⁷⁷ Apart from the fact that it would have encouraged the chauvinists in France and angered the Germans almost to desperation, it might well have involved the fall of the Liberal government. A secret alliance was out of the question. The British Cabinet therefore sought to escape from its dilemma by informal promises which in theory were not binding. There is little doubt that Mr. Asquith and Sir Edward Grey thought they had retained their liberty of action, and their sin-

⁷¹ *Collected Dipl. Docs.*, pp. 354-361.

⁷² Pribram, II. 215, 223.

⁷³ Joffre, *La Préparation de la Guerre et la Conduite des Opérations* (1920), p. 21. He speaks of "nos conventions militaires avec l'Angleterre".

⁷⁴ Churchill, I. 115.

⁷⁵ Sazonov's reports to the Tsar, Aug. 17, November, 1912, in *Livre Noir*, II. 339, 347. There is at present no way to determine whether Sazonov correctly reported what Poincaré and Grey said to him. Francis Dyke Acland, parliamentary under-secretary for foreign affairs from 1911 to 1915, has declared (*Journal of the British Institute of International Affairs*, January, 1923, p. 47): "In fact Lord Grey had answered 'No' on various occasions when France had asked whether, if war resulted in certain circumstances, she could rely on British support." A statement by the British government is greatly to be desired.

⁷⁶ Mr. Churchill's speech before the Committee of Imperial Defence, July 11, 1912. Asquith, pp. 77-79.

⁷⁷ Cf. Earl Loreburn, *How the War Came* (1919), pp. 11-16, 19-20.

cerity is attested by their hesitations in July, 1914. But there is equally little doubt that the French were confident of British support. "England is not bound to France by any definite political engagement", said M. Poincaré to Izvolski in February, 1913, "but the tone and the nature of the assurances given by the cabinet of London allow the French government, in the existing political conjunctures, to count upon the armed support of England in case of conflict with Germany."⁷⁸ Mr. Churchill was right when he wrote: "Every one must feel who knows the facts that we have the obligations of an alliance without its advantages, and above all without its precise definitions."⁷⁹

The value attached by the British Foreign Office to the understanding with Russia can be gaged by two incidents: in 1908 Sir Edward Grey accepted the principle of opening the Straits at Constantinople,⁸⁰ and in 1912 he told Count Benckendorff, the ambassador in London, that if the Entente broke down, he would resign.⁸¹ It is therefore in no way surprising that in the spring of 1914, by which time the Russian navy had become an appreciable factor in the international situation, conversations respecting operations in the Baltic were begun by the British and Russian admiralties.⁸² The Russian diplomatists, who had first suggested the negotiations, expressed the "greatest satisfaction"⁸³ at the complaisance exhibited by the British, and though they did not get the alliance for which they hankered,⁸⁴ they were greatly encouraged by the substitution of "something tangible" for "the hitherto all too theoretical and peaceful basis of the Entente".⁸⁵ The episode is of extreme importance, for it appeared to the French and the Russians as the final step in the consolidation of the Triple Entente; just as the German-Italian military arrangements of a month before marked the rejuvenation of the Triple Alliance. Thus, at last, the two diplomatic groups stood face to face, on the very eve of Serajevo.

Was war the inevitable result of such a situation? The several governments constantly declared their alliances strictly defensive and affirmed their desire for peace; moreover, it is now fairly certain that

⁷⁸ Izvolski to Sazonov, Feb. 27, 1913, *Livre Noir*, II. 32-33.

⁷⁹ Churchill to Asquith, Aug. 23, 1912, Churchill, I. 116.

⁸⁰ Grey to Izvolski, Oct. 14, 1908, *Livre Noir*, II. 458. The British government, however, insisted that the Straits must be opened to the ships of all nations (*cf. infra*, p. 468), and thought the moment inappropriate for action.

⁸¹ Benckendorff to Sazonov, Feb. 8, 1912, Siebert, p. 739.

⁸² Siebert, pp. 818-821.

⁸³ Sazonov to Benckendorff, May 28, 1914, Siebert, p. 817.

⁸⁴ Sazonov to Izvolski, Apr. 2, 1914, *ibid.*, p. 807.

⁸⁵ Benckendorff to Sazonov, May 18, 1914, *ibid.*, p. 813.

no responsible statesman in any country,⁸⁶ as distinct from military cliques,⁸⁷ actually desired war.⁸⁸ The trouble was that each group suspected the good faith of the other; and not without reason. For although both alliances had been formed to preserve the *status quo*, both had been modified, the Triple Alliance in 1887,⁸⁹ the Dual Alliance in 1899,⁹⁰ so as to permit changes in the *status quo*. And that delicate structure was becoming increasingly fragile. The Balkan Peninsula and the Habsburg monarchy presented problems which

⁸⁶ It cannot be seriously contended that Mr. Asquith and Sir Edward Grey were otherwise than pacifically inclined; it is clear also that Bethmann, in his clumsy way, worked for peace, and the same can be said of M. Sazonov, although both he and Bethmann sanctioned or pursued policies that greatly endangered peace. The case against M. Poincaré rests chiefly on what Izvolski reported to his government. Thus, on Jan. 30, 1913, after M. Poincaré had been elected president: "The French government is firmly resolved to fulfill its obligations to us as an ally in the fullest extent, and it admits in good conscience and with all the necessary *sang-froid* that the ultimate result of the existing complications may make it necessary for France to take part in a general war." For the Germans this is quite sufficient. Schoen, in *Deutschland und die Schuldfrage* (1923), p. 25; Montgelas, *Leitfaden zur Kriegsschuldfrage* (1923), p. 49. But, Izvolski goes on: "The moment when France will have to draw the sword is precisely determined by the Franco-Russian military convention; in this connection, the French ministers do not feel the least doubt or hesitation." *Livre Noir*, II. 20. For France to support Russia's Balkan policy was neither more nor less dangerous or warlike than it was for Germany to stand behind Austria.

⁸⁷ The three fat volumes of memoranda published by Conrad von Hötzendorf, the chief of the Austrian general staff, show with what zeal he tried to persuade Aehrenthal and Berchtold to bring on war while the situation was still, as he thought, favorable for the Monarchy; but in vain. Eckardstein (*Isolierung Deutschlands*, p. 184) records an interview with Moltke on June 1, 1914. After hearing the ex-diplomatist's gloomy analysis of the international situation, the chief of the general staff said: "What you have told me interests me uncommonly. If it does have finally to boil over, we are ready, and the sooner it does, the better for us." In France there had been quite an output of pamphlets by soldiers to prove that the chances of a French victory were excellent.

⁸⁸ By "war" is meant a European war. German, Austrian, and Russian statesmen were quite willing for the Balkan states to fight Turkey or each other.

⁸⁹ Pribram, I. 109, 113. Germany promised her assistance to Italy, not only for the realization of the latter's African ambitions, but also "if the fortunes of any war undertaken in common against France should lead Italy to seek for territorial guaranties with respect to France for the security of the frontiers of the Kingdom and of her maritime position"; and Austria and Italy arranged for mutual compensation in the event that "the maintenance of the status quo in the region of the Balkans or of the Ottoman coasts and islands in the Adriatic and in the Aegean Sea should become impossible".

⁹⁰ *Ibid.*, II. 219. There was interpolated in the political agreement of 1891, which bound the two governments to "take counsel together upon every question of a nature to jeopardize the general peace", an understanding to maintain "the European balance of power". This addition was made in expectation of the break-up of Austria-Hungary, but the words actually used opened the way to all kinds of possibilities.

would some day have to be faced; when solutions could no longer be postponed, and the Turkish revolution of 1908 made a Balkan settlement imperative, the doctrine of the balance of power would compel the two groups to take position against each other.

Then, again, no government knew what arrangements its own allies might be making on the side. The Germans were rightly suspicious of Italy's "extra dances"⁹¹ with France and Russia. France was never sure that Russia would not come to terms with Germany, as, in fact, Russia tried to do more than once.⁹² Sir Edward Grey was haunted by the fear of "one great combination in Europe, outside which we should be left without a friend".⁹³ The frequent assurances of mutual support in the diplomatic exchanges show that the governments in alliance trusted each other little more than they did those of the opposing group. So there was generated a state of mind which is admirably reflected in a sentence from one of Izvolski's despatches: "With God's help the conflict may be postponed, but that it will come some day we must remember every hour, and every hour we must arm ourselves for it."⁹⁴

Hence the armed peace. It was unquestionably German example that forced the other Continental countries to adopt universal military service, but France always kept a larger percentage of her population with the colors than her rival, and in the years before the war the Russian army was larger than the German and the Austrian put together; on the other hand, Russia did not conscript one per cent. of her population, which was the German rule.⁹⁵ Figures of the moneys spent for armaments have to be handled very carefully, for the military budgets of the different states did not include the same items;⁹⁶ it is also probable that if Germany and Austria spent less than France and Russia, they got more for their money. As the British forces were raised on a volunteer basis, they were much more expensive than the victims of the conscript system. But these refinements are really beside the point, for every government, while balking some-

⁹¹ Bülow's phrase, Reichstag, Jan. 8, 1902. Bülow, *Reden*, II. 31.

⁹² Björkö and Potsdam have already been mentioned (above, p. 455, 456). Shortly before the war Russia is said to have conveyed privately to Germany the suggestion: "Si vous pouviez vous décider à lâcher les Autrichiens, nous pourrions lâcher la France." Helfferich, I. 172; Bethmann, p. 86.

⁹³ Speech to the Imperial Conference, 1911, Asquith, p. 125.

⁹⁴ Izvolski to Neratov, Dec. 20, 1911, Siebert, p. 448.

⁹⁵ Cf. Montgelas, in *Deutschland und die Schuldfrage*, pp. 73-78, and Montgelas, *Leitfaden*, pp. 11-16.

⁹⁶ The French military estimates included the gendarmerie and the colonial troops; the German estimates did not include pensions.

times at the extreme demands of its general staff,⁹⁷ created as large an army and navy as the economic resources and the public opinion of the country would permit; without—and this is the irony of the race to ruin—creating either actual security or even a feeling of security. No document is more illuminating than a report of the German general staff drawn up in December, 1912,⁹⁸ in which it is practically confessed that in spite of forty years' military effort, in spite of the Triple Alliance, the position of the German Empire, at least as seen through general-staff spectacles, was threatened on all sides. A memorandum on the naval situation presented by Mr. Churchill to the British Cabinet in December, 1913, is conceived in a similar strain.⁹⁹ When the supreme test came, the breakdown of diplomacy was induced as much by military panic as by the bellicose velleities of this or that power.

How completely all were caught in a vicious circle is shown most clearly in the Anglo-German negotiations of 1912.¹⁰⁰ The Germans said: We cannot discuss a limitation of armaments unless Great Britain will abandon the Entente, for so long as you stand with France and Russia, they will cherish schemes of revenge or aggression. To which the British replied: So long as you go on with your navy, we cannot give up the insurance provided by the Triple Entente, especially as you are protected by the Triple Alliance. When Admiral von Tirpitz offered to yield on the fleet in return for a promise of unconditional neutrality, Lord Haldane answered that Great Britain was bound by treaty to Portugal and Japan and had certain obligations towards Belgium. Neither was willing to yield anything essential. The British insisted on both their naval supremacy and their diplomatic combinations, for thus the balance of power was turned against Germany. To restore the balance in their favor, the Germans had to retain their freedom in armaments or break up the Entente. Each position was logical, so long as the theory of equilibrium controlled the actions of diplomacy.

There was one man, however, who had the vision of a new order, and that was Sir Edward Grey. Although the British foreign secretary assumed from time to time, as in early stages of the Bagdad

⁹⁷ The German general staff wanted three more corps in 1912-1913 than the government would grant; Bethmann prevented Tirpitz from getting as many ships as he wanted in 1912. Mr. Lloyd George, in January, 1914, publicly protested against the ever-growing naval estimates.

⁹⁸ E. Ludendorff, *The General Staff and its Problems* (1920), I. 60-64.

⁹⁹ Churchill, I. 184-186.

¹⁰⁰ Asquith, pp. 97-102; Churchill, I. 95-113; Haldane, pp. 55-72, 145-149. Bethmann, pp. 49-59; Tirpitz (English edition), I. 282-296; William II., (English edition), pp. 146-160; Bernhard Huldermann, *Albert Ballin* (1922), pp. 164-184.

Railway question or in Morocco, an attitude frankly hostile to Germany, although he steadily strengthened the Triple Entente as a bulwark against Germany, that was only one side of his activity. He was so far from pursuing a policy of encirclement that he told Count Benckendorff that the isolation of Germany would be the surest road to war.¹⁰¹ What he desired and worked for was an understanding with Germany, on the condition, as he phrased it, that it "must not put us back into the old bad relations with France and Russia".¹⁰² If this could be achieved, then the way would be open to the creation of an effective concert of Europe. "Sir Edward Grey's aim", says the German historian Veit Valentin, "was a new Europe in which the existing causes of conflict should be allayed and an understanding reached about armaments."¹⁰³

Sir Edward was at heart a pacifist,¹⁰⁴ in spite of all he did to improve the military arrangements of the Entente, and he perceived more clearly than any of his contemporaries not only that the armaments race must have a fatal conclusion, but that the co-operation of the Great Powers must be substituted for their antagonism before a limitation of armaments could be discussed. Hence he was constantly recommending the Concert of Europe to the Continental governments. If his handling of the Bosnian crisis is open to some criticism,¹⁰⁵ nevertheless he was standing out for the principle that the affairs of the Near East must be adjusted by consent of all the powers; and that he was right was soon demonstrated, for Russia replied with a great military and naval programme to the settlement dictated by Germany and Austria. If the Moroccan negotiations between France and Germany in 1911 had broken down, it was Sir Edward's intention to propose a European conference.¹⁰⁶ During the Balkan wars and after, not only did he refuse to embark on any course of action which would set off the Triple Entente against the Triple Alliance, but he insisted, often to the annoyance of France and Russia, on associating Germany in every step.¹⁰⁷ Ultimately he

¹⁰¹ Benckendorff to Izvolski, Feb. 10, 1909, Siebert, p. 728.

¹⁰² Speech to the Imperial Conference, 1911, Asquith, p. 124.

¹⁰³ Veit Valentin, *Deutschlands Aussenpolitik* (1921), p. 124.

¹⁰⁴ So the writer has been assured by persons in a position to know.

¹⁰⁵ Schmitt, pp. 294-295; Ward and Gooch, III. 411.

¹⁰⁶ Paul Cambon to de Selves, Aug. 23, 1911, French *Livre Jaune, Affaires du Maroc*, vol. VI. (1912), no. 517. Cf. also Benckendorff to Neratov, July 5, 1911, Siebert, p. 426.

¹⁰⁷ Cf. *Affaires Balkaniques, passim*. Prince Lichnowsky, who was a member of the conference of ambassadors in London, states that Grey "wished to mediate between the two groups as an 'honest broker'". *My Mission to London* (1918), p. 10. In the Liman von Sanders affair (below, p. 466) he refused to follow Sazonov in a vigorous protest and preferred to negotiate a compromise with Germany; Siebert, pp. 642-651.

hoped to effect, as indeed he proposed in 1912¹⁰⁸ and again in 1914,¹⁰⁹ an agreement between the powers that they would not attack each other.

For the failure to realize this lofty ideal, Sir Edward Grey was, in a sense, himself responsible. His public statements on the one hand that he was a free agent, and his private assurances to France on the other, encouraged both Continental groups to gamble, the one on British neutrality, the other on British support. But in this very fact, rather than in his equivocations, is contained the real reason for Grey's failure. The conception of a Concert of Europe made little appeal to the Continental Powers,¹¹⁰ not because any one of them was bent on war, but because each alliance was determined to establish its supremacy in the councils of Europe. Each side hoped to accomplish this without recourse to war, but because both felt sure of Great Britain each was willing to run the risk of war, and to accept war, if that were necessary to secure its ascendancy. And victory would rest with that group which could control the march of events in the Near East.

The plans of the Germans are familiar enough to us. They intended, by means of the Bagdad Railway¹¹¹ and by reorganizing the Turkish army, to reduce the Ottoman Empire to economic and political vassalage. The sending of General Liman von Sanders in January, 1914, to command the garrison of Constantinople¹¹² was at once an index of their confidence and a warning to others; and if, under Russian pressure, the German officer's function had to be changed to that of inspector-general,¹¹³ it was all the easier for him

¹⁰⁸ The formula offered the Germans: "Aggression upon Germany is not the subject and forms no part of any treaty, understanding or combination to which England is now a party, nor will she become a party to anything that has such an object." Asquith, p. 56.

¹⁰⁹ "My own endeavor will be to promote some arrangement to which Germany could be a party, by which she could be assured that no aggressive or hostile policy would be pursued against her or her allies by France, Russia, and ourselves, jointly or separately." Sir Edward Grey to Sir Edward Goschen, July 30, 1914, *Collected Dipl. Docs.*, p. 78.

¹¹⁰ It is of course not to be denied that both France and Germany co-operated with Great Britain in 1912-1913 in making the Concert work, and M. Poincaré was as anxious as Sir Edward Grey to maintain the unity of the Powers. The long negotiations, however, served to emphasize rather than minimize the fundamental conflict between the two alliances.

¹¹¹ The fullest account is in E. M. Earle, *Turkey, the Great Powers, and the Bagdad Railway* (1923).

¹¹² Cf. Liman von Sanders, *Fünf Jahre Türkei* (1920), ch. I.

¹¹³ The diplomatic correspondence may be read in Siebert, ch. XVII., and *Affaires Balkaniques*, III. 82-109; cf. also Schwertfeger, IV. 168-172. According to Helfferich, the military details were worked out by the German general staff,

to train the Turkish soldiers in Anatolia and prepare the way for the Turko-German alliance of August 1, 1914.

The Austrians, in turn, were to extend their influence over the Balkans, though not, as has often been supposed, by the crude method of advancing to Salonika. The plans of Count Aehrenthal, as sketched for the Emperor Francis Joseph on the eve of the annexation of Bosnia, called for an alliance with Bulgaria, who should be promised the reversion of Macedonia, and an independent Albania under Austrian patronage.¹¹⁴ Serbia would then be so surrounded by enemies that she would have to submit to the dictation of Vienna, and the Karageorgevitch dynasty could be left as a harmless expression of national existence. Aehrenthal was content to bide his time, perceiving as he did that his programme could be carried out only in the event of European complications: it is all the more significant, therefore, that Count Berchtold was playing with the same ideas in June, 1914, before the assassination of the Archduke Francis Ferdinand.¹¹⁵ It will be observed that neither Germany nor Austria aimed at annexing territory, so that they could easily deny any aggressive designs; but it must be obvious that the success of their schemes would give them practical control over the vast region stretching from Belgrade to the Persian Gulf.

To the Russians, of course, such a prospect was intolerable. As a counterweight to Austria they organized the Balkan League,¹¹⁶ to be let loose against the Habsburg monarchy¹¹⁷ or the Ottoman Empire as circumstances might require; and to prevent Serbia from coming to terms with Austria, they held out promises of future assistance which were exceedingly dangerous to the cause of peace.¹¹⁸ But without regard for the political effects. The Foreign Office paid no attention to the military details. Hence Bethmann did not inform Sazonov, who passed through Berlin in November, of the composition of the mission, and the latter thought he had been tricked. Karl Helfferich, *Die Deutsche Türkenpolitik* (1921), p. 29.

¹¹⁴ Friedjung, II. 241.

¹¹⁵ Joseph to William II., July 2, 1914, and the accompanying memorandum. *Diplomatische Aktenstücke zur Vorgeschichte des Weltkrieges*, vol. I., no. 1; *Die Deutschen Dokumente zum Kriegsausbruch*, vol. I., nos. 13, 14.

¹¹⁶ Siebert, ch. III.

¹¹⁷ Article V. of the Russo-Bulgarian Military Convention of December, 1909, stated that "the realization of the high ideals of the Slavic peoples upon the Balkan peninsula . . . is possible only after a favourable outcome of Russia's struggle with Germany and Austria-Hungary". Bogitshevitch, p. 90; Laloy, p. 55.

¹¹⁸ The president of the duma told a Serbian diplomatist that "we shall consider any attempt to coerce Serbia as the beginning of a European conflagration". Koshutitch to Serbian Foreign Office, Mar. 19, 1909, Bogitshevitch, p. 112; *Deutschland Schuldig?* annex VI., app. 10. "The Minister of Foreign Affairs told me that Serbia was the only State in the Balkan[s] in which Russia had confidence, and that Russia would do everything for Serbia." Popovitch to Belgrade, Feb. 4, 1913,

Serbia was less important in the eyes of the Russian government than the Bosphorus and the Dardanelles. As early as 1908 Izvolski had worked out a scheme which would allow three Russian men-of-war at a time to pass the Straits without a corresponding privilege being allowed the ships of other powers,¹¹⁹ and the idea runs like a red thread through the subsequent years. First, the Turks were tempted, during the Tripolitan War, by the offer of an alliance;¹²⁰ when they refused, Russia made no effort to save them from the Balkan crusade of 1912, and during those feverish days great pressure had to be exerted by France and Great Britain to prevent the despatch of a Russian fleet to the Golden Horn.¹²¹ Finally, in February, 1914, after the Germans had shown their hand in the Liman von Sanders affair, a secret council of Russian ministers and military experts prepared a scheme for seizing the Bosphorus in case a European war should break out.¹²²

At Constantinople, then, two mighty currents were meeting at right angles, the Russian streaming to the southwest, the German to the southeast. The Russians felt that they must open the Straits because their commerce had suffered grievous losses from the closing of the Dardanelles in 1912; the avowed intent of Germany to strengthen Turkey in a military way, which would militate against the opening of the Straits, was explained by the necessity of securing a free field for German enterprise. In Asiatic Turkey a compromise was perhaps possible, for in the spring of 1914 a series of agreements divided the dominions of the Sultan into spheres of influence for railway exploitation by the several rival powers.¹²³ The Turkish government was also, as it were, put in commission, for if a German

Bogitshevitch, p. 99. "Again Sazonov told me that we must work for the future because we would acquire a great deal of territory from Austria." Popovitch to Belgrade, Apr. 29, 1913, Bogitshevitch, pp. 99-100. In February, 1914, the Tsar promised Pashitch, the Serbian premier, that Russia would supply Serbia with munitions, and sent to the Serbian king the message, "For Serbia we shall do all". Pashitch's report, Feb. 2, 1914, Bogitshevitch, pp. 130, 134; *Deutschland Schuldig?* annex VI., app. 26. An English writer interprets these promises as a Russian device to prevent Serbia from precipitating war (J. W. Headlam-Morley, "Russian Diplomacy before the War", in *Quarterly Review*, January, 1922), but they left the Serbs masters of the situation. Whether Russia was planning a deliberate attack on Austria-Hungary or waiting for that antiquated political machine to collapse of its own rottenness is still, at least so it seems to the writer, an open question.

¹¹⁹ *Livre Noir*, II. 457.

¹²⁰ Siebert, ch. XVIII.; *Livre Noir*, II. 458-464.

¹²¹ *Affaires Balkaniques*, II. 25-30, 260, 264-265, 272; *Livre Noir*, II. 1-4, 111-113.

¹²² Protocol of the meeting in Laloy, pp. 74-101, and *Deutschland Schuldig?* annex X., app. 1.

¹²³ Earle, ch. X.

general was in charge of the army, a British admiral was reorganizing the navy, and a Frenchman commanded the gendarmeries. Nevertheless, a conflict of interests remained which showed itself quite clearly in the question of Armenian reforms, when the Entente Powers supported the Russian programme and the Triple Alliance helped Turkey to modify it.¹²⁴ On the whole, it would seem that German influence was steadily mounting at the Sublime Porte; just when an alliance was first mooted is uncertain, but there is no doubt that Enver and Talaat Pashas overbore the French sympathies by which Djemal Pasha, the other member of the ruling triumvirate, claimed to have been animated.¹²⁵

In the Balkans the Treaty of Bucharest (August, 1913) was followed by much jockeying for position on the part of both Balkan kingdoms and Great Powers. Amidst the welter of intrigue, the outstanding fact seems to be that Bulgaria, disgusted by the hard terms imposed upon her and holding Russia responsible for them, began negotiations for a Turkish alliance, which was very nearly concluded in May, 1914;¹²⁶ while from March on she was herself courted by the Central Powers and preferred to raise a loan in Berlin rather than in Paris.¹²⁷ In midsummer, 1914, nothing was settled. But if "the isolation and diminution of Serbia"¹²⁸ could be effected, and Bulgaria won by the cession of Macedonia, the Teutonic road to the East would be secure, and the hegemony of the Balkans and of Europe would pass to the Triple Alliance. The incentive to an active policy was probably not weakened by the confidence of Germany in both Italian loyalty and British neutrality.

Russia was bound to resist any move directed against Serbia. For Rumania, after being for thirty years a satellite of the Triple Alliance,¹²⁹ was now veering round to friendship with France and Russia,¹³⁰ and a Serbo-Rumanian wedge between Austria and Bulgaria would certainly stop the *Drang nach Osten*, if it did not make the Dual Alliance the arbiter of Balkan politics. Thus Serbia had become the key to the whole European situation. Russia could resist

¹²⁴ Djemal Pasha, p. 271.

¹²⁵ *Ibid.*, pp. 101-107, 75.

¹²⁶ *Ibid.*, pp. 55-56; A. F. Pribram, *Austrian Foreign Policy, 1908-1918* (1923), pp. 50-51.

¹²⁷ For Franco-Russian efforts to save the situation in their favor, see Siebert, pp. 632-638.

¹²⁸ The phrase used by Francis Joseph in his letter of July 2, 1914, to William II.

¹²⁹ The treaty was renewed on Feb. 26, 1913. Pribram, I. 267.

¹³⁰ Siebert, pp. 615-618; *Livre Noir*, II. 377-384; Austrian memorandum of July, 1914.

the Austro-German schemes the more confidently because her military reorganization was nearly completed¹³¹ and because she was sure of French assistance.

France had no direct interest in the Balkans, but if she declined to stand with Russia, the Dual Alliance would be shattered, the balance of power destroyed, and the Treaty of Frankfort ratified by the dead weight of Germany's greater population and superior resources for war. In these tragic circumstances France had no alternative, unless she was to abdicate as a great power, but to follow Russia; not blindly, for the assurances of support were limited to the terms of the treaty of alliance, but in the long run the Russians held the trump cards. M. Poincaré seems to have described the situation accurately when he said to Izvolski: "France is undoubtedly peacefully inclined, neither looking for war nor desiring it, but if Germany goes against Russia, this state of mind will change immediately."¹³² So long as great armaments and the balance of power were the main-springs of European policy, France, like every other state, was ready to fight rather than face isolation by leaving her ally in the lurch.¹³³

So the stage was set for a trial of strength between the two great diplomatic combinations, each of which was armed to the teeth. In June, 1914, William II. and the Archduke Francis Ferdinand met, for the last time, at Konopischt. Their talk was about Rumania, according to the most authentic account,¹³⁴ but the Russian general staff received reports to the effect that they had agreed to an Austrian attack on Serbia, with German assistance if necessary. This information was passed on to the intelligence section of the Serbian general staff, which was presided over by a Colonel Dragutin Dimitryevitch, born conspirator, a regicide of 1903, the leading spirit in the "Society of Union or Death" or "Black Hand", and chief of the

¹³¹ At least the war minister thought so. He inspired a famous article in the *Bourse Gazette*, Mar. 13, 1914. "Russia wishes for peace, but is ready for war. The army is not only large, but excellently equipped. Russia has always fought on Russian soil and has always been victorious. Russia is no longer on the defensive. Russia is ready." Exactly three months later there was another fanfare in the same tone, which concluded with the sentence: "Russia and France do not wish for war, but Russia is ready, and France must be also."

¹³² Izvolski to Sazonov, Sept. 12, 1912. *Livre Noir*, I. 326; *Deutschland Schuldig?* annex viii, app. 4.

¹³³ Count Benckendorff, the Russian ambassador in London, went so far as to say that "of all the Powers France is the only one that, not to say that it wishes war, would see it without great regret". Report to Sazonov, Feb. 25, 1913, *Livre Noir*, II. 304; *Deutschland Schuldig?* annex VIII., app. 10.

¹³⁴ Report of Treutler, minister in the German emperor's suite, to the Foreign Office, June 14, 1914. Montgelas, *Leitfaden*, pp. 191-194; *Am. Hist. Rev.*, XXIX. 311-312.

military party that was scheming to overthrow Premier Pashitch and take control of the country. Dimitryevitch conceived the notion that the murder of the archduke would be a prophylaxis against the impending Austrian invasion, and, while he was in this mood, his friend and confidant, Major Voijs Tankositch, appeared on the scene with two Bosniaks who were anxious to assassinate Francis Ferdinand. Dimitryevitch then made the arrangements which culminated in the catastrophe of June 28, 1914. When he informed the "Black Hand" of what he had done, it was aghast and persuaded him to countermand his orders; he claimed later that he tried to do so, but said that he was not obeyed. Such is the account vouched for by a Serbian historian, who denies that the Serbian government was in any way implicated.¹³⁵ Just what was the relation of the Austrian government to the tragedy and why there was not adequate police protection in Serajevo are mysteries that are still discussed and still unsolved.¹³⁶

A month later both bloated armaments and serried alliances proved their futility. Bethmann-Hollweg and Count Berchtold hoped to bluff Russia into accepting the Austrian ultimatum and a military expedition against Serbia. M. Sazonov thought that by mobilization of the Russian army he could bluff Austria into foregoing her action against Serbia. Bethmann-Hollweg thought that by threat of war he could bluff Russia into retracting her mobilization. M. Viviani tried to bluff Germany by refusing to state what France would do, and so did Sir Edward Grey as to Great Britain. Not one of them desired a European conflagration, but each, for fear that his bluff would be called, sanctioned all military measures short of actual war, and these measures enabled the soldiers in Germany, who were "jumpy" in the extreme, to take control of the situation.¹³⁷ Whether the German general staff was justified in making the Russian mobilization¹³⁸ a *casus belli* is a much-discussed question; but discussion

¹³⁵ Stanoje Stanojevitch, *Die Ermordung des Erzherzogs Franz Ferdinand* (1923), pp. 43-56.

¹³⁶ R. Recouly, "L'énigme de Sérájévo", in *Revue de France*, Apr. 1, 1922 (*Living Age*, May 6, 1922); Prince V. Ghika, "Le Meurtre de Sérájévo", in *Revue Universelle*, Apr. 15, 1923 (*Living Age*, June 9, 1923).

¹³⁷ Professor S. B. Fay ("New Light on the Origins of the War", III., in *Am. Hist. Rev.*, XXVI. 251) shows that the German militarists got control on July 31, when the news of the Russian mobilization was received. In Russia, however, in spite of much pressure from the soldiers, it was Sazonov who persuaded the Tsar to order mobilization.

¹³⁸ The full story of the Russian mobilization has been told by Gen. Sergei Dobrorolski, the chief of the mobilization section of the Russian general staff, in his pamphlet, *Die Mobilmachung der Russischen Armee, 1914* (1922). From the very beginning of the crisis, the general staff regarded war as inevitable. Sazonov, however, hoped for peace until the Austrian declaration of war against Serbia. He

of it should not obscure the fact that this mobilization was ordered because Austria refused all concessions and that Austria refused all concessions because she was absolutely sure of German backing. In other words, not one of the three protagonists was willing to accept a diplomatic defeat, for the stake at issue was nothing less than the domination of the Near East; whichever side yielded, the rival diplomatic combination emerged as the director of European politics. It is perfectly true that when Bethmann perceived war to be imminent, under conditions different from those imagined at the moment the promise of support to Austria was given—for Italian neutrality and British intervention were looming up—he tried to draw back and exerted considerable pressure on Vienna.¹³⁹ But his action came too late, for he was unable to obtain concessions from his ally in time to stave off the Russian mobilization: he failed to prevent the war because he clung too long to his original plan of scoring a resounding triumph for the Triple Alliance. It can, however, be pleaded in Bethmann's favor that whereas he did, in the end, try to restrain Austria, France made but little effort to restrain Russia,¹⁴⁰ and France must therefore share with Germany the responsibility for then called for a general mobilization, and the ukase was signed on July 29. But before the orders could be sent off, they were countermanded by the Tsar, who substituted a partial mobilization. It was long believed that the general staff disobeyed the Tsar and went ahead with the general mobilization. Dobrorolski shows that this was not the case. The general mobilization was ordered on the afternoon of July 30, as a consequence of the general situation, the studied refusal of Austria to make any concessions, and the equivocal attitude of Germany. The argument was also used that the alliance with France bound Russia to mobilize if Austria mobilized (*cf.* Pribram, *Secret Treaties*, II. 215), and Austria had ordered a partial mobilization. But no orders to attack Germany were issued. Sazonov informed the French government that Russia would continue her military preparations until "an absolutely satisfactory answer from Austria had been received through the agency of the German government" (Sazonov to Izvolski, July 30, 1914, in *Livre Noir*, II. 292, and Romberg, p. 36).

¹³⁹ Bethmann to Tschirschky, July 27, 1914, in *Die Deutschen Dokumente zum Kriegausbruch*, no. 279; July 28, *ibid.*, no. 323; July 29, *ibid.*, no. 361; July 30, *ibid.*, nos. 395, 396.

¹⁴⁰ The French government did urge its ally not to take any steps which would give Germany an excuse to mobilize, and even suggested that "in the higher interests of peace" Russia might declare her willingness "to slow down her preparations for mobilization for the time being". Izvolski to Sazonov, July 30, 1914, nos. 208, 210, in *Livre Noir*, II. 290, and Romberg, pp. 36, 37. But France did not suggest that Russia should alter her attitude, for it had been bluntly informed that Russia would not do so. Sazonov to Izvolski, July 27, 1914, in *Livre Noir*, II. 280, and Romberg, p. 20. That France preferred war to sacrificing the alliance is seen from the statement made to Izvolski, at 1 a.m. on Aug. 1 (that is, after the German ultimatum practically demanding French neutrality had been received), that "the French government has firmly decided on war". Izvolski to Sazonov, Aug. 1, 1914, in *Livre Noir*, II. 294, and Romberg, p. 41.

making the fate of Serbia a clear-cut issue between the Triple and the Dual Alliances. But if France cannot be credited with any positive step to preserve peace, she is certainly absolved from what is the most serious charge against Germany. For Sir Edward Grey saw that the only escape from the *impasse* was to bring the Concert of Europe into action, and his proposal to that end was accepted by France, Russia, and Italy. It was the refusal of Germany to follow this lead, before the diplomatic situation had been overtaken by military measures, which made Great Britain finally range herself with France and Russia, prevented a compromise between the Alliance and the Entente, forced each group to maintain its position, and thus precipitated the war.

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